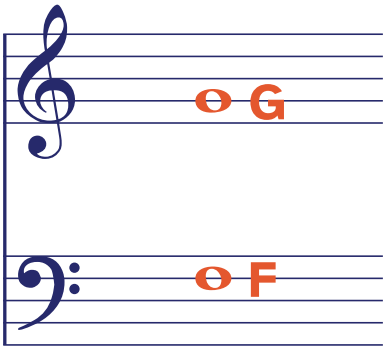
PART I · PITCH · 2

The staff and the clefs

Music lives on a **staff** (or stave): five lines and four spaces, counted from the **bottom**. Higher on the staff means higher in sound. The **clef** at the start is the code: it says which note each line and space stands for.

THE SECRET

The treble clef curls round G; the bass clef's two dots hug F.



The treble clef curls round G · the bass clef's dots hug F

CLEF	NAME	HOW IT SHOWS ITS NOTE	FIRST MET
𝄞	**treble clef** (G clef)	curls round the line for G (line 2)	Level 0
𝄢	**bass clef** (F clef)	its two dots sit either side of the line for F (line 4)	Level 0



Alto clef: middle C on line 3. Used by the viola.

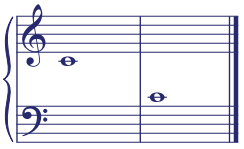


Tenor clef: middle C on line 4. Cello, bassoon and trombone, up high.

Other clefs. C clefs: the line through the centre of the clef is middle C. Piano music never uses them, but pianists meet them in theory exams and when reading the viola or cello part in chamber music or a score (Level 2).

The grand staff

Piano music uses two staves joined by a brace: the treble staff, usually for the right hand, above the bass staff, usually for the left. **Middle C** sits between them on a short line of its own, and can be written in either staff.

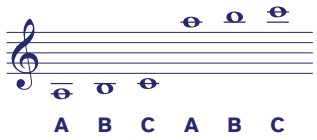


Middle C in the treble staff (left) and in the bass staff (right): the same key.

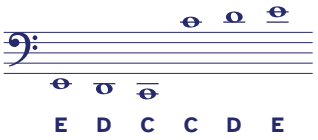
Ledger lines

Notes above or below the staff sit on short extra lines called **ledger lines**, spaced like the staff lines.

PART I · PITCH · 2 · CONTINUED



Treble: A, B, C below; A, B, C above.



Bass: E, D, C below; C, D, E above.

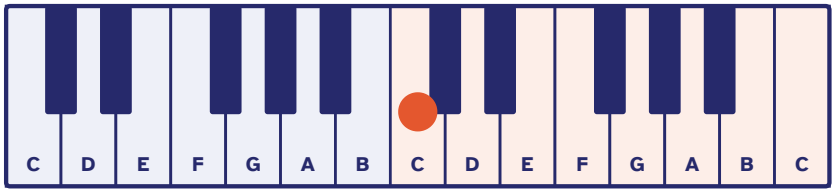
Octave signs

SIGN	MEANING
8va	an octave higher, as far as the dotted line
8vb	an octave lower
loco	back where it is written

First met: Level ½. Octave signs save writing many ledger lines: a high passage stays on the staff, with 8va above it.

EXAMPLE

Which staff does this note belong to?
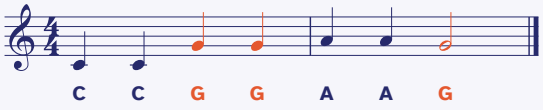


1. **Below middle C** (blue): the bass staff, usually the left hand.
2. **Above middle C** (pink): the treble staff, usually the right hand.
3. **Middle C itself** (the red dot): either staff, whichever hand plays it.

Low keys: **bass clef**. High keys: **treble clef**. The two staves meet at middle C.

YOU KNOW THIS

Twinkle, Twinkle, Little Star



The treble clef curls round **line 2: G**, the very note Twinkle leaps up to. Middle C hangs on its own ledger line below.

Try it. Point to the G line, then play C C G G A A G.

THINK OF IT A clef is a pair of glasses: the same five lines read as different notes, depending on which pair you put on.

TRAP

× Reading bass-clef notes as if they were treble: check the clef on every line.

SEE ALSO
Reading the notes p. 26 · The staff and the keyboard p. 28

PRACTISE IT
Workbook Pitch 2 · Online: Library › Staff and clefs

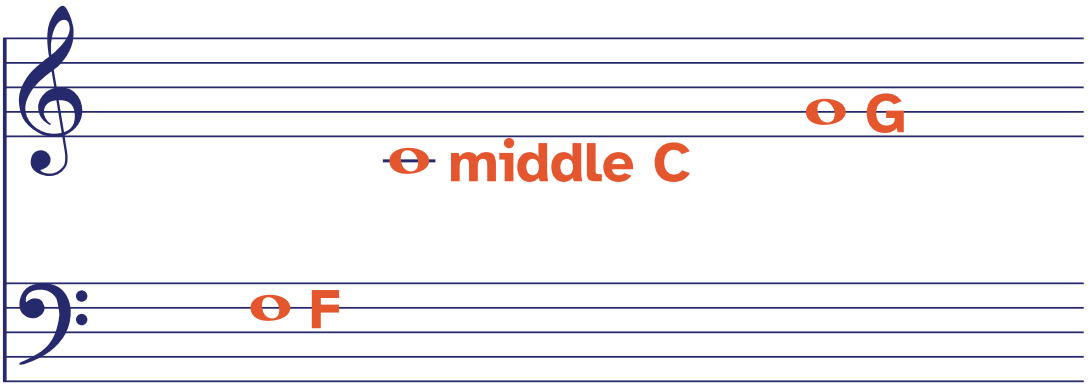
PART I · PITCH · 3

Reading the notes

Each line and space has one letter name. Learn them in two ways: by the patterns below, and by a few **landmark notes** you can find instantly and count from.

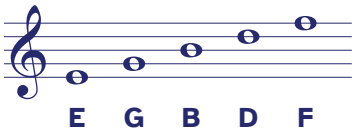
THE SECRET

Learn three landmark notes, then step or skip from them.



Find a landmark, then count

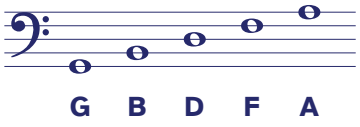
Find the three red **landmark notes** first: bass F, middle C, treble G. Every other note is a **step** (line to space) or a **skip** (line to line) away from one of them.



Treble clef: the lines



Treble clef: the spaces



Bass clef: the lines



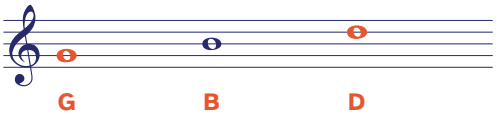
Bass clef: the spaces

STAFF	NOTES, BOTTOM TO TOP	TO REMEMBER
Treble lines	E G B D F	*Every Good Boy Deserves Fun*
Treble spaces	F A C E	spells *FACE*
Bass lines	G B D F A	*Great Big Dragon Flies Away*
Bass spaces	A C E G	*All Cows Eat Grass*

PART I · PITCH · 3 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 1

Read a note you are not sure of

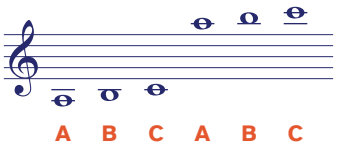


1. **The clef:** treble.
2. **A landmark:** the G the clef curls round, on line 2.
3. **Skip up** line to line, one letter jumped each time: G, B, D.

The note on line 4 is **D**.

EXAMPLE 2

Read a ledger-line note
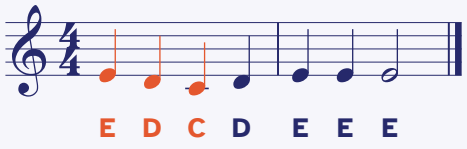


1. **Start at the staff edge:** the top line of the treble staff is F.
2. **Step up** one note at a time: G (space), A (first ledger line).
3. **Below the staff** count down the same way: D, C, B, A.

Ledger lines are the staff carried on: count by steps from the nearest line.

YOU KNOW THIS

Mary Had a Little Lamb



E D C: **line, space, ledger line**, one step down each time. Read the shape and the tune walks down with it.

Try it. Read the notes aloud before you play them.

THINK OF IT Landmark notes are like lamp posts on a dark road: walk from one to the next and you are never lost.

TRAP

- × Naming bass-clef notes with treble names: in the bass, the bottom line is G, not E.
- × Counting ledger lines from the wrong end: start from the staff and count outwards.

SEE ALSO

The staff and the clefs p. 24 · The staff and the keyboard p. 28

PRACTISE IT

Workbook Pitch 2 · Online: Library › Staff and clefs

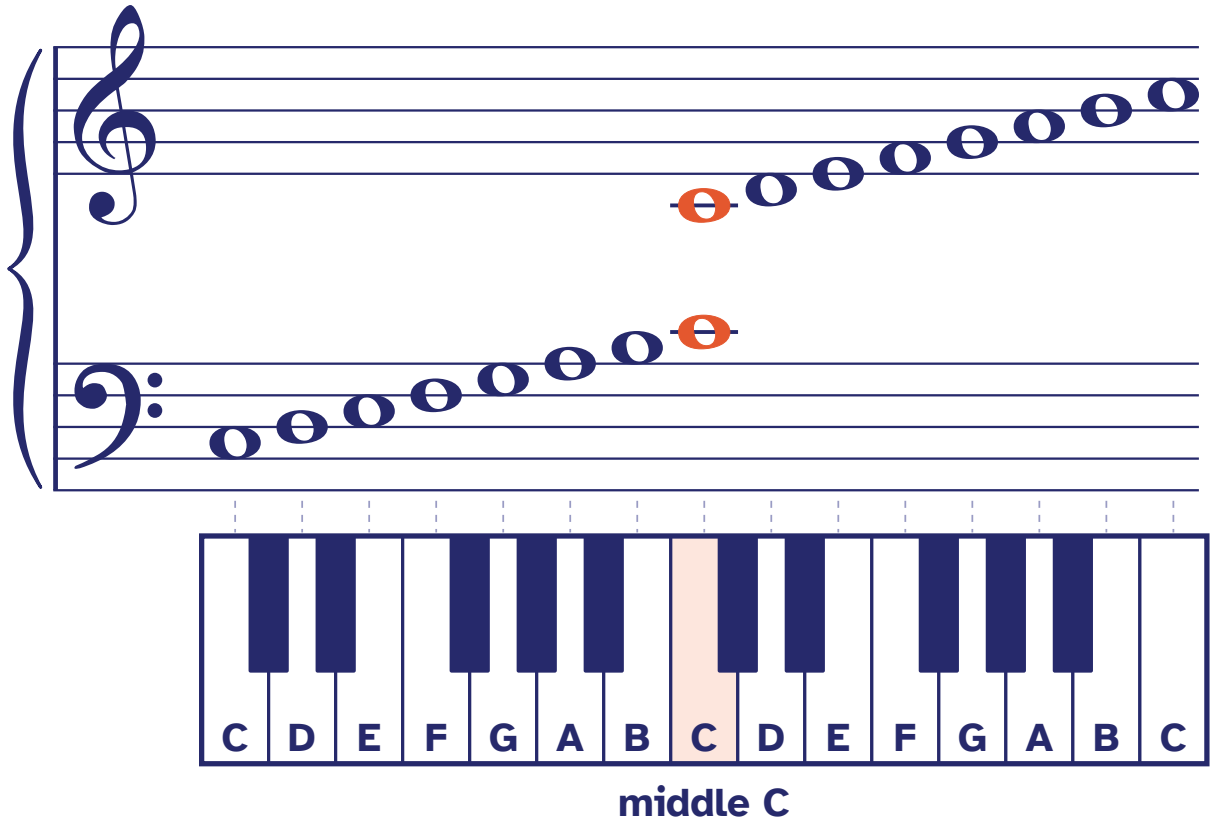
PART I · PITCH · 4

The staff and the keyboard

Every line and space of the grand staff is one white key. Read from left to right, the notes climb the staff exactly as the keys climb the keyboard: two octaves from C3 to C5, with middle C in red where the two staves meet.

THE SECRET

Every line and every space is one white key, in order.



What the map shows

Each step up the staff (line to space, space to line) is the next **white** key. The black keys have no line or space of their own: they are written with a sharp or a flat on a white key's line or space (p. 30).

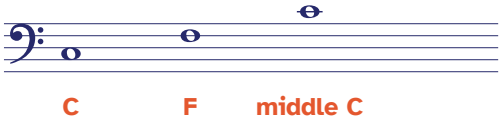
Two ways to write one key

Middle C can sit on a ledger line below the treble staff or above the bass staff. Both mean the same key; the music chooses the staff of the hand that plays it.

PART I · PITCH · 4 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 1

From the page to the key

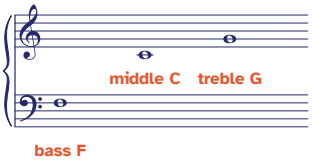


1. **Name the note on the staff:** line 4 of the bass staff, between the clef's dots, is F.
2. **Count down from middle C:** C B A G F, the fifth white key down.
3. **Play it** with the left hand: that is F3.

The bass-clef F is **F3**, five white keys below middle C.

EXAMPLE 2

Landmarks either side of middle C

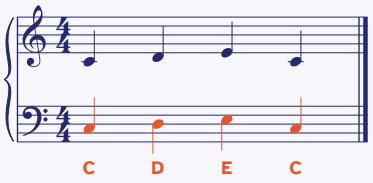


1. **Find middle C** on the map: between the two staves.
2. **Treble G** is five white keys above it.
3. **Bass F** is five white keys below it.

The landmarks sit at the same distance either side of middle C.

YOU KNOW THIS

Frère Jacques, in both hands



The left hand plays the **same letters**, C D E C, one octave lower, written in the bass clef.

Try it. Play it right hand, then left hand, then both together.

THINK OF IT The staff is a ladder laid on its side beside the keyboard: each rung, a line or a space, is the next white key.

TRAP

× Thinking the black keys have their own lines: they borrow a white key's line or space with a sharp or flat.

SEE ALSO
The keyboard p. 22 · Reading the notes p. 26

PRACTISE IT
Workbook Pitch 1–2 · Online: Library › Staff and clefs